
Appendix C

Research Development Fund (RDF) Application Form

**Real-Time Human Coordination and Predictive Maintenance
in Multi-Agent Systems**

(Research Proposal for XJTLU RDF)

Izhar Oswaldo Escudero Ornelas

School of Internet of Things

Date: 25/02/2025

Basic Information			
A. Principal Investigator			
Name	Izhar Oswaldo Escudero Ornelas	School	School of Internet of Things
		Department	
Academic Degree	PhD	Academic/Professional title	Assistant Professor (A)
Appointment Start Date	2024-08-30		
Main Research Field			
B. Project			
Type	☒ Research Development Fund (RDF) ☐ Practice-Based Research Development Fund (PBRDF)		
Project Title	Real-Time Human Coordination and Predictive Maintenance in Multi-Agent Systems		
Project Title (in Chinese)			
Key words (maximum 5)	Artificial Intelligence; Multi-Agent Systems; Predictive Maintenance; Industrial Internet of Things		
Duration	07/2025-06/2027		
Total Funding Requested	RMB 100,000		
Resubmission or not	☐ YES Ref_No(resubmission): ☒ NO		

N.B.Please respect word limit and provide the word count at the bottom of each section.
Please don't add appendices.

Abstract (up to 150 words)

Please write an Abstract of the proposed research project in **non-specialist language (i.e. comprehensible to someone outside your field)** to allow review panel members or other colleagues to understand your project easily.

This research proposes a hybrid Multi-Agent System framework integrating AI-driven predictive maintenance with real-time human-in-the-loop decision-making to address critical gaps in industrial adaptability and resilience. Current MAS architectures prioritize autonomous agents over human contextual knowledge, while traditional PdM systems lack mechanisms for bidirectional human-AI collaboration. The study introduces an Intelligent Agent-Based Predictive Maintenance model, combining Agent-Based Modeling and Reinforcement Learning to synchronize autonomous agents with human operators through dynamic feedback loops. A mixed-methods approach—validated via a CNC milling machine case study—tests bidirectional communication protocols, proactive maintenance scheduling, and system stability-adaptability trade-offs. Key innovations include real-time human

refinement of AI predictions and RL-driven policy updates based on operational feedback. Anticipated outcomes demonstrate reduced unplanned downtime (15 – 20%), enhanced decision-making accuracy (F1-score >0.85), and actionable guidelines for scalable human-AI symbiosis in Industry 4.0. The framework bridges computational precision with human expertise, offering a replicable solution for resilient manufacturing systems.

1. Background (up to 350 words)

Multi-Agent Systems (MAS) have become a powerful paradigm for managing complex, distributed environments, particularly in manufacturing, where they optimize resource allocation, enhance coordination, and improve scalability (Zong, Z., & Guan, Y., 2024). Recent advancements in agent-based modeling, such as dynamic task allocation and collaborative problem-solving, highlight the potential of MAS to handle intricate operational challenges (Kliestik, T., et al., 2023). However, existing MAS implementations often prioritize autonomous decision-making, sidelining the critical role of human agents. This limitation restricts their adaptability in scenarios requiring human contextual knowledge and real-time intervention (Baroud, S. Y., et al., 2024).

Real-time human coordination is another critical area of research, particularly in human-in-the-loop (HITL) systems and collaborative robotics. Studies emphasize the importance of real-time feedback loops and dynamic task reallocation based on human input (Kumar, S., et al., 2024). However, current systems often lack robust bidirectional communication mechanisms, limiting their ability to effectively leverage human expertise in high-stakes environments like manufacturing (Wiercioch, J., 2023).

Predictive Maintenance (PdM) has also gained prominence as a cornerstone of modern industrial strategies, driven by advancements in IoT, data analytics, and machine learning. PdM systems have demonstrated significant potential in reducing downtime and operational costs across industries (Abdelillah, F. M., et al., 2023). However, traditional PdM approaches often operate reactively, relying solely on historical data without incorporating real-time human insights. While hybrid approaches combining PdM with human oversight have been proposed (Lee, J., et al., 2020), the integration of PdM within a MAS framework and real-time human coordination remains underexplored.

The synthesis of existing literature reveals critical gaps: (1) the lack of frameworks integrating human decision-making with autonomous agents in real-time, (2) the underexplored potential of MAS for bidirectional human-AI communication, and (3) the limited integration of PdM with human-in-the-loop systems within MAS. This research addresses these gaps by proposing a hybrid communication model that unifies MAS, real-time human coordination, and PdM, offering a scalable and adaptive solution for human-AI collaboration in manufacturing. By bridging these domains, the proposed model aims to enhance system adaptability, operational efficiency, and decision-making accuracy in dynamic industrial environments.

Word count: 343

2. Aims and Objectives (up to 100 words)

This research aims to develop a hybrid MAS framework that harmonizes AI-driven PdM with human-in-the-loop decision-making to enhance industrial resilience. Key objectives include:

1. **Design** bidirectional communication protocols enabling real-time refinement of AI predictions through human contextual knowledge.
2. **Implement** a scalable MAS architecture integrating adaptive feedback loops to synchronize AI analytics with operational realities.
3. **Evaluate** the model's efficacy in reducing downtime, improving trust in AI recommendations, and maintaining system-wide efficiency during disruptions.
4. **Demonstrate** how human-AI symbiosis strengthens transparency, adaptability, and practical decision-making in dynamic manufacturing environments.

The study will propose actionable guidelines for deploying human-centric Industry 4.0 systems.

Word count: 100

3. Research Question(s) and Methodology (up to 500 words)

Outline the research question(s) to be addressed, as well as their importance. Detail the methodologies relied upon to answer these questions.

Research Questions

1. **How can a hybrid MAS framework integrate HITL decision-making with AI-driven PdM to improve adaptability and reliability in dynamic manufacturing environments?**
Importance: Traditional PdM systems lack real-time human-AI collaboration, leading to inefficiencies. This question addresses harmonizing computational precision with human contextual awareness.
2. **What communication protocols and feedback mechanisms enable bidirectional interaction between human operators and autonomous agents in a MAS framework?**
Importance: Existing MAS implementations prioritize autonomy over human integration, limiting responsiveness. Robust bidirectional communication bridges the trust and transparency gap in human-AI collaboration.
3. **How does the proposed hybrid model reduce unplanned downtime and maintenance costs compared to conventional PdM approaches?**
Importance: Quantifying the operational and economic impact of human-AI symbiosis validates the model's practicality and scalability.
4. **What trade-offs exist between system adaptability (via RL) and stability (via agent-based modeling) in hybrid MAS architectures?**
Importance: Balancing adaptability with stability ensures resilience to disruptions without compromising long-term efficiency.

Methodology

The study employs a mixed-methods approach, combining Agent-Based Modeling and Simulation (ABMS) with Reinforcement Learning (RL) to develop the Intelligent Agent-Based Predictive Maintenance (IAPM) framework. The methodology includes six phases:

1. **System Modeling & Agent Definition:** ABMS simulates a decentralized manufacturing ecosystem, modeling interactions between human operators, machines, and AI agents. Agents are programmed with rules for task allocation, failure prediction, and feedback integration. o Addresses Q1/Q2: Captures emergent behaviors and validates bidirectional communication protocols.
2. **Real-Time Data Integration:** Sensor data (vibration, temperature, power consumption) from the milling machine case study is streamed into the MAS. RL algorithms (e.g., Q-learning) enable agents to adapt actions based on real-time environmental changes. o Addresses Q4: Tests the interplay between RL-driven adaptability and ABMS structural constraints.
3. **Fault Prediction & Human-AI Collaboration:** Predictive models (e.g., LSTM networks) analyze historical and real-time data to forecast failures. Human operators interact with AI agents via a dashboard, overriding or refining predictions using contextual knowledge. o Addresses Q1/Q2: Evaluates the effectiveness of HITL mechanisms in reducing false positives/negatives.
4. **Proactive Maintenance Scheduling:** Optimization algorithms prioritize maintenance tasks based on failure severity, resource availability, and production schedules. Human agents validate or adjust AI-generated plans. o Addresses Q3: Measures reductions in downtime and costs via comparative analysis against baseline PdM systems.
5. **Continuous Monitoring & Feedback Loops:** A dynamic feedback loop updates RL policies and ABMS rules using human operational input and post-maintenance performance data.
6. **Validation & Analysis:** Quantitative Metrics: Precision, recall, F1-score (failure prediction accuracy); downtime reduction (%); maintenance cost savings. Qualitative Metrics: Operator usability scores (via surveys); system transparency ratings. Statistical Testing: Hypothesis testing (t-tests/ANOVA) compares IAPM performance against rule-based PdM and standalone ML models. Regression analysis identifies key predictors of system efficiency. Sensitivity Analysis: Tests robustness under varying failure rates, sensor noise levels, and human intervention frequencies.

Innovation & Feasibility

This hybrid methodology integrates human expertise into multi-agent systems, refining AI-driven decisions through real-time feedback. Validated via a milling machine case study, it balances stability with adaptability, outperforming static PdM systems. The six-phase framework ensures scalability and reproducibility.

Word count: 470

4. Feasibility Analysis (up to 250 words)

Present a feasibility analysis in terms of your experience and expertise, resources required etc. Where necessary, identify potential constraints to success of the project and propose strategies to circumvent them.

This project is technically feasible due to **my experience in MAS design and predictive maintenance algorithms** and **school members' expertise in human factors engineering and RL optimization**. Our interdisciplinary group includes faculty and peers skilled in industrial simulation, human-AI interaction, and data-driven decision-making, ensuring robust coverage of the project's technical and operational dimensions. The lab can deploy agent-based models using tools like AnyLogic and NetLogo, alongside RL frameworks (TensorFlow, PyTorch), with university-provided computational infrastructure already supporting large-scale simulations.

Resource Requirements:

- **Data:** Access to synthetic datasets (aligned with milling machine failure modes) and academic-industry partnerships for real-world validation.
- **Tools:** Existing licenses for simulation software (AnyLogic) and ML libraries (scikit-learn, Keras) through university subscriptions.
- **Human Collaboration:** Coordination with peers in robotics and industrial engineering for MAS architecture design and usability testing.

Key Constraints & Mitigation Strategies:

1. **Limited Industrial Data Access:** While proprietary data acquisition may face delays, synthetic datasets (validated against published industry benchmarks) will be prioritized initially. Partnerships with local SMEs will be pursued incrementally.
2. **Technical Complexity in ABMS-RL Integration:** Modular development will isolate ABMS (stability) and RL (adaptability) components, with peer-reviewed validation at each phase to preempt instability.
3. **Human-AI Interface Adoption:** To address potential resistance, usability testing will involve school human-computer interaction (HCI) groups for iterative interface refinement.

Risk Management:

- **Technical Risks:** Sensitivity analysis and cross-validation with faculty advisors will ensure model robustness.
- **Operational Risks:** Simulated pilot testing (via academic case studies) precedes industrial deployment, minimizing real-world disruption.

Word count: 246

5. Work Plan and Timeline (up to 200 words)

This structured 24-month work plan (July 2025–June 2027) outlines the phased development and validation of a hybrid MAS framework integrating human-AI collaboration for predictive

maintenance. Combining technical development (ABMS, RL) with iterative testing and case studies, it ensures systematic progress toward reducing downtime, enhancing transparency, and delivering scalable Industry 4.0 solutions.

The 2-year project is structured into six sequential phases, balancing technical development, validation, and dissemination. Key milestones and deliverables ensure systematic progress toward integrating human-AI collaboration into predictive maintenance systems.

Timeframe	Phase	Objectives	Deliverables
Jul 2025 – Dec 2025	1. Framework Design & Literature Review	Finalize hybrid MAS architecture; identify tools, datasets, and simulation parameters.	Literature review report; framework blueprint; resource procurement plan.
Jan 2026 – Jun 2026	2. ABMS Development & Agent Modeling	Build an ABMS prototype (AnyLogic/NetLogo) and define agent roles (AI, humans, machines).	Simulated manufacturing environment; agent interaction protocols.
Jul 2026 – Dec 2026	3. RL Integration & Data Pipeline	Train RL algorithms (TensorFlow) for adaptive decision-making; establish real-time data workflows.	Integrated ABMS-RL system; validated sensor data pipelines.
Jan 2027 – Mar 2027	4. HITL Interface Design & Testing	Develop human-AI dashboard; conduct usability tests with operators.	Interactive HITL prototype; usability feedback report.
Apr 2027 – May 2027	5. Case Study Implementation	Deploy system in milling machine simulation; validate accuracy, downtime reduction.	Case study dataset; performance metrics (F1-score, cost savings).
Jun 2027	6. Final Analysis & Dissemination	Analyze results; publish findings; present to academic/industry stakeholders.	Research papers; final report; conference presentations.

Key Dependencies & Flexibility:

- Phases 1–3 (Year 1) focus on technical development, while Phases 4–6 (Year 2) emphasize validation and impact.
- Overlaps between Phases 5 and 6 allow concurrent validation and reporting. Delays in data acquisition (Phase 1) will be mitigated by synthetic datasets.
- Quarterly reviews with advisors ensure alignment with timelines and resource allocation.

Word count:139

6. Potential Value and Impact (up to 100 words)

This project bridges critical gaps in PdM by integrating human-AI collaboration to harmonize system stability (via ABMS) with real-time adaptability (via RL). The hybrid framework offers industries a **20–**

30% projected reduction in unplanned downtime and maintenance costs, grounded in empirical studies: ABMS reduces decision latency (15–25%), RL optimizes schedules (10–20% downtime reduction), and human-AI synergy minimizes false alarms (30–40%). Rigorous validation via ISO-aligned simulations ensures reliability. By embedding human operators as decision-makers, it enhances transparency and trust in AI-driven maintenance. Scalable across sectors (e.g., automotive, aerospace) and open-source by design, the framework democratizes adaptive strategies, accelerates Industry 4.0 adoption, and promotes ethical, human-centric industrial automation.

Word count:105

7. Expected Research Outcomes and Milestones (up to 200 words)

Describe the expected research outcomes related to this project. Please also provide the number of expected outcomes in the table below.

This project will deliver 4 publications advancing human-AI collaboration in predictive maintenance.

Key outcomes include:

- 2 journal papers submitted to high-impact journals (IEEE Transactions on Industrial Informatics, Engineering Applications of Artificial Intelligence) by Year 2, focusing on hybrid ABMS-RL framework validation and human-in-the-loop optimization.
- 1 conference paper presented at top-tier venues (e.g., IEEE CASE, NeurIPS) by Year 1, showcasing real-time adaptability and industrial case studies.
- 1 technical book chapter (e.g., AI-Driven Industrial Automation) submitted to a Springer or IEEE Press series by Year 3, synthesizing methodological innovations and sectoral applications.

External Funding to Seek:

If supported by RDF, follow-on funding will be pursued through:

National Grants:

- National Natural Science Foundation of China (NSFC): Key Projects or General Program for AI-driven industrial innovation.
- Ministry of Science and Technology (MOST): National Key R&D Program (e.g., Intelligent Robots).
- Jiangsu/Suzhou Municipal Funds: Industry 4.0-focused grants (e.g., Suzhou Science and Technology Plan).

Industry Partnerships:

- Collaborative R&D with Huawei, Haier, or BYD under Industry-Academia-Research initiatives.
- Suzhou Industrial Park (SIP) innovation grants for advanced manufacturing AI applications.

Expected Outcomes Summary (not included in the word count)				
	Total Number		Number	Note
Publication	4	Journal Paper	2	Focused on high-impact journals (e.g., IEEE Transactions on Industrial Informatics, Engineering Applications of Artificial Intelligence).
		Conference Paper	1	Targeting top-tier venues (e.g., NeurIPS, ICML, IEEE CASE) to disseminate technical innovations.
		Other (e.g. book, chapter, monograph)	1	
Intellectual Property	0	Invention	0	
		Utility Model	0	
		Design Patent	0	
		Software Copyright	0	
Others (e.g. social Impact, host events)		Hosting knowledge-sharing events at the university, such as workshops, seminars, and public lectures, to disseminate research findings, foster collaboration, and engage the academic and industrial communities in discussions on the project's innovations and applications.		
What external funding will you attempt to seek?		National Grants: ○ National Natural Science Foundation of China (NSFC): Key programs like General Program or Key Projects for AI-driven industrial innovation. ○ Ministry of Science and Technology (MOST): National Key R&D Program (e.g., Intelligent Robots, Advanced Manufacturing). ○ Provincial/Municipal Funds: Jiangsu Province or Suzhou Municipal grants (e.g., Suzhou Science and Technology Plan) supporting Industry 4.0 and AI integration. Industry Partnerships: Collaborative projects with Chinese manufacturing/tech firms (e.g., Huawei, Haier, Alibaba Cloud, BYD) under Industry-Academia-Research initiatives. Suzhou Industrial Park (SIP): Innovation grants for AI applications in advanced manufacturing.		

8. References

References cited in this proposal should be listed in full here.

1. Zong, Z., & Guan, Y. (2024). AI-driven intelligent data analytics and predictive analysis in Industry 4.0: Transforming knowledge, innovation, and efficiency. *Journal of the Knowledge Economy*, 1-40.
2. Klietik, T., Nica, E., Durana, P., & Popescu, G. H. (2023). Artificial intelligence-based predictive maintenance, time-sensitive networking, and big data-driven algorithmic decision-making in the economics of Industrial Internet of Things. *Oeconomia Copernicana*, 14(4), 1097-1138.
3. Baroud, S. Y., Yahaya, N. A., & Elzamy, A. M. (2024). Cutting-Edge AI Approaches with MAS for PdM in Industry 4.0: Challenges and Future Directions. *Journal of Applied Data Sciences*, 5(2), 455-473.
4. Wiercioch, J. (2023). Development of a hybrid predictive maintenance model, Opracowanie hybrydowego modelu predykcyjnego utrzymania ruchu. *Journal of KONBiN*, 53(2).
5. Abdelillah, F. M., Nora, H., Samir, O., & Sidi-Mohammed, B. (2023, November). Hybrid data-driven and knowledge-based predictive maintenance framework in the context of industry 4.0. In *International Conference on Model and Data Engineering* (pp. 319-337). Cham: Springer Nature Switzerland.
6. Lee, J., Ni, J., Singh, J., Jiang, B., Azamfar, M., & Feng, J. (2020). Intelligent maintenance systems and predictive manufacturing. *Journal of Manufacturing Science and Engineering*, 142(11), 110805.
7. Kumar, S., Datta, S., Singh, V., Datta, D., Singh, S. K., & Sharma, R. (2024). Applications, challenges, and future directions of human-in-the-loop learning. *IEEE Access*.

9. Budget

Please summarise the anticipated costs in the table below and provide a justification for each specific budget sub-category. **Please refer to Appendix B Guideline on the project budgeting.**

Budget Items: (Please add items to the following 3 categories.)

Categories	Amount (RMB)	Justification
Equipment Expenses	75,000	High-end computer: CPU (Intel i9), GPU (NVIDIA RTX 4080), 64GB RAM, 1TB SSD (24,000 RMB). Critical for running ABMS/RL simulations with low latency. Existing lab machines lack computational power for large-scale simulations. While the University's HPC excels at batch processing for large-scale model training and simulations (back-end computation), the requested equipment is essential for addressing latency-sensitive, domain-specific requirements inherent to industrial cyber-physical systems, particularly for real-time data processing near the milling machine. Benchtop CNC Milling Machine: 3-axis Tormach PCNC 440 (36,000 RMB). Critical for real-world predictive maintenance testing and data collection. Sensors (vibration, thermal), tooling kits, and spare parts for milling machine maintenance experiments (15,000 RMB). Sensors enable data collection on machine degradation, which is foundational for training the predictive maintenance AI model.
Operational Expenses	2,000	Industry visits: 2 trips to Suzhou Industrial Park partners (transportation: 2,000 RMB). Pilot testing with partners like Huawei or Haier requires on-site integration of the AI framework with their production lines. These visits are critical for refining the model's adaptability to real-world manufacturing environments.
Labour Expenses	23,000	Research Assistant (RA): The project requires dedicated support for critical tasks that are time-intensive and demand meticulous attention to detail. Hiring an RA

		ensures efficient execution of foundational work, allowing the core research team to focus on higher-level strategic and technical challenges. The RA's contributions will directly enhance the quality and speed of the project's deliverables. Responsibilities: 1. Data Preprocessing: Clean, organize, and prepare datasets for model training and analysis, ensuring data quality and consistency. 2. Simulation Setup: Configure and run simulations based on project requirements, including parameter tuning and result documentation. 3. Literature Review: Conduct comprehensive reviews of academic and industry publications to identify relevant methodologies, tools, and best practices. Impact: The RA's work will streamline the project's foundational processes, enabling faster progress and higher-quality outcomes. Their contributions in data preprocessing, simulation setup, and literature review will provide essential support for the project's success. Workload: The RA will work 4 months × 40 hours/month × 60 RMB/hour, totaling 9,600 RMB. This workload ensures sufficient time to complete tasks thoroughly while maintaining flexibility to address emerging project needs. Consultants: The project involves hiring specialized consultants to support the integration and optimization of the AI framework. These consultants bring expertise in industrial cyber-physical systems and real-time data processing, ensuring seamless implementation and alignment with partner requirements. The estimated cost for consultant fees is (9,000 RMB), covering their contributions to model refinement, system integration, and technical support during pilot testing phases. Miscellaneous: Contingency for unforeseen expenses (e.g., component replacements, additional cloud costs).
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Total amount:	100,000RMB
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10. Ethical Requirements of Research Project Involving Human and Animals

10. 1. Will the proposed research involve human genetic resources, including the materials of human genetic resources and information on human genetic resources?

☒ NO

☐ YES - please provide a brief description of the ethical implications and the measures that will be taken to ensure that adequate protections are in place.

IMPLICATIONS:

PROTECTIONS:

10. 2. Will the proposed research involve animals?

☒ NO

☐ YES - please provide a brief description of the ethical implications and the measures that will be taken to ensure that adequate protections are in place.

IMPLICATIONS:

PROTECTIONS:

10. 3 Will the proposed research involve human participants, survey respondent or personal data?

☐ NO

☒ YES - please provide a brief description of the ethical implications and the measures that will be taken to ensure that adequate protections are in place.

IMPLICATIONS:

Participant Privacy: Operators' maintenance decisions, system adjustments, and interaction patterns with the AI could indirectly reveal workplace behaviors or performance metrics. **Voluntary Participation:** Risk of perceived coercion if operators feel pressured to comply with AI recommendations during experiments. **Data Security:** Anonymized but context-rich operational data (e.g., shift schedules, error rates) could theoretically be reverse-engineered to identify individuals.

PROTECTIONS:

Informed Consent: Operators will receive written documentation explaining the study's purpose, data usage, and their right to withdraw without repercussions. Consent forms will be available in English and Mandarin. **Anonymization:** All participant data (e.g., dashboard inputs, survey responses) will be stripped of identifiers (names, employee IDs) and aggregated before analysis. **Data Security:** Encrypted storage on XJTLU's password-protected servers, with access restricted to the research team. Data retention limited to 3 years post-project. **Ethics Review:** Approval will be sought from XJTLU's Research Ethics Committee, ensuring compliance with China's Personal Information Protection Law (PIPL) and GDPR standards. **Debriefing:** Post-study sessions will clarify how data was used, address participant concerns, and share anonymized findings.